Altering Hypnosis to Suggestibility

Understanding whether a person is more physically or emotionally suggestible helps hypnotists choose the most effective techniques and suggestions.

For Physically Suggestible Individuals: Hypnotists might use more concrete, sensory, and direct suggestions. Techniques like progressive relaxation, arm levitation, and direct physical suggestions are often effective.

For Emotionally Suggestible Individuals: Hypnotists might use more abstract, emotional, and indirect suggestions. Techniques like visualization, metaphorical language, and emotionally charged narratives are often effective. By recognizing and adapting to an individual's type of suggestibility, hypnotists can enhance the effectiveness of their sessions and achieve better therapeutic outcomes.

Laws of Suggestibility

The laws of suggestibility in hypnosis outline principles that help explain how and why people respond to hypnotic suggestions. These laws provide a framework for understanding how these suggestions are processed and accepted by the mind. They guide hypnotists in formulating effective suggestions and creating conditions that maximize the likelihood of achieving the desired outcomes. These laws were primarily developed by early hypnotists and psychologists to better understand the mechanisms of hypnosis. Here are some key laws of suggestibility:

Law of Concentrated Attention: The more one concentrates on a particular idea or suggestion, the more likely it is to be accepted and acted upon. Focused attention enhances the absorption of the suggestion.

Example: **If a hypnotist asks a subject to focus intensely on the idea of their hand feeling warm, the subject's concentrated attention on that sensation can cause the hand to actually feel warmer. The more the subject concentrates, the more likely they are to experience the suggested warmth.**

Law of Reversed Effect (or Law of Reverse Action):

The harder one tries to do something, the less likely they are to succeed if there is a conflict between the conscious effort and the subconscious mind. For example, trying too hard to relax may actually cause more tension. Example: A person trying to fall asleep may find that the harder they try, the more awake they feel. In hypnosis, if a subject tries too hard to relax, they may become more tensed. Instead, the hypnotist might suggest that relaxation will come effortlessly, allowing the subject to relax without effort.

Law of Dominant Effect: **A stronger or more dominant idea will override weaker suggestions. Emotions and strong beliefs often have a more significant impact on suggestibility than neutral or weak suggestions. Example: If a person is under hypnosis and the hypnotist suggests that they feel calm and relaxed, but there is a sudden loud noise (a dominant stimulus), the person may react to the noise rather than the suggestion of calmness. The stronger stimulus overrides the hypnotic suggestion.**

Law of Association:

Ideas that are linked together in the mind will reinforce each other. If a suggestion is associated with a known and accepted fact or experience, it is more likely to be accepted. Example: If a hypnotist suggests that a subject's favourite food smells wonderful and tastes delicious, and the subject has positive past experiences with that food, the subject is more likely to experience the suggestion vividly because of the strong association with past experiences.

Law of Belief:

What one believes to be true will become their reality. If a person genuinely believes in the effectiveness of a suggestion, they are more likely to respond positively to it. Example: If a person believes that hypnosis can help them quit smoking, they are more likely to respond positively to suggestions for quitting. The belief in the effectiveness of hypnosis enhances the power of the suggestions given during the session.

Law of Repetition: Repeating a suggestion multiple times can increase its effectiveness. Repetition helps reinforce the idea in the subconscious mind, making it more likely to be accepted. Example: A hypnotist might repeatedly suggest to a subject that they are becoming more confident every day. Through repetition, this idea becomes reinforced in the subject's subconscious mind, making it more likely to influence their behaviour and self-perception over time.

Law of Imagination:

The imagination is more powerful than willpower. If a person can vividly imagine a suggestion, their subconscious mind is more likely to accept it as reality. Example: If a hypnotist asks a subject to vividly imagine walking on a beach, feeling the sand under their feet, and hearing the waves, the subject's imagination can create a powerful sensory experience. This vivid imagery can influence the subject's state of relaxation more effectively than simply being told to relax.

Law of Expectation: A suggestion is more likely to be effective if the subject expects it to work. Positive expectations can enhance the response to hypnosis. Example: If a subject expects that hypnosis will help them reduce pain, their anticipation and belief in this outcome can enhance the effectiveness of hypnotic pain relief suggestions. Their expectation sets a positive frame for the suggestion to take hold.

Law of Substitution:

If a new suggestion is presented to replace an old belief or habit, it is more likely to be accepted if the new suggestion is perceived as more beneficial or desirable. Example: To help a person overcome a fear of public speaking, a hypnotist might suggest that every time the subject feels nervous, they will instead feel excitement and enthusiasm. By substituting the old fear with a new, positive feeling, the subject is more likely to accept and integrate the new response.

Law of Growing Emotion: Emotions tend to amplify the effect of suggestions. A suggestion linked with strong emotions will have a more profound impact. Example: During hypnosis, a hypnotist might suggest that as the subject thinks about achieving a personal goal, they feel an increasing sense of joy and accomplishment. The growing emotional intensity associated with the goal can make the suggestion more compelling and motivating.

Law of Delayed Action:

If there is an idea you put in associated with a triggering mechanism, the idea will take control whenever the trigger is initiated. Example: During hypnosis suggest a subject whenever he sees a pack of cigarettes, will feel a strong dislike and an urge to drink a glass of water instead. The client leaves the session feeling relaxed but doesn't immediately notice any significant change. The next day, the client sees a pack of cigarettes on the table, feels an unexpected, strong dislike. Simultaneously, the client experiences a strong urge to drink water. These examples illustrate how each law of suggestibility can be applied in hypnosis to create effective and impactful suggestions. Understanding these laws helps hypnotists tailor their techniques to enhance the likelihood of achieving the desired outcomes for their subjects.

Suggestibility Tests

Some tests are practiced to understand the level of suggestibility. Suggestibility tests in hypnosis are used to convert a subject into hypnosis and to determine an individual's responsiveness to hypnotic suggestions. These tests help the hypnotist measure how easily a person can enter a hypnotic state and respond to hypnotic suggestions. The idea is that during the suggestibility test the hypnotist is building up message units. The hypnotist should begin all suggestibility tests by saying that the suggestibility test of the client is being tested. It is not a matter of FAIL or PASS, therefore the client need not help or hinder the hypnotist in any way. Some common suggestibility tests include:

1. Arm Levitation Test: The subject is asked to imagine their arm becoming lighter and lifting up on its own. The hypnotist observes if the arm rises, indicating a higher level of suggestibility.

2. Finger Interlock Test: The subject is instructed to clasp their hands together tightly and imagine that their fingers are stuck together and cannot be separated. The difficulty in separating the fingers suggests higher suggestibility.

3. Balloon and Book Test: The subject is asked to hold out their arms, imagining one hand holding a heavy book and the other tied to a helium balloon. The arm with the imaginary book may lower while the arm with the balloon may rise, showing suggestibility.

4. Postural Sway Test: The subject is asked to stand with their eyes closed and imagine a gentle push forward or backward. Observing whether they sway in the suggested direction indicates their level of suggestibility.

5. Lemon Test: The subject is asked to imagine biting into a juicy lemon and to describe their physical reaction. Salivating or grimacing can indicate high suggestibility.

6. Eye Catalepsy Test: **The subject is asked to close their eyes and imagine that they are unable to open them. If they find it difficult or impossible to open their eyes, it indicates higher suggestibility.**

7. Pendulum Test: **The subject is asked to hold a pendulum (or any small weight on a string) and imagine it swinging in a particular direction. If the pendulum begins to move as suggested, it indicates high suggestibility.**

8. Magnetic Hands Test: **The subject is instructed to hold their hands a few inches apart and imagine a powerful magnet pulling their hands together. If the hands move closer without conscious effort, it indicates suggestibility.**

9. Light-Heavy Hands Test:

Similar to the Balloon and Book Test, the subject is asked to hold out their arms and imagine one hand getting lighter (like it's holding a balloon) and the other getting heavier (like it's holding a weight). Observing any involuntary movement indicates suggestibility.

10. Eye Fixation Test: **The subject is asked to focus on a particular spot or object while the hypnotist gives suggestions of their eyelids feeling heavy and closing. If the eyes close involuntarily, it shows suggestibility.**

11. Numerical Regression Test:

The subject is asked to count backwards from a certain number, imagining each number makes them more relaxed and drowsy. The hypnotist observes how easily the subject follows this suggestion and how their behaviour changes.

12. Finger Stiffness Test: **The subject is asked to extend one finger and imagine it becoming stiff and rigid, unable to bend. If the finger remains stiff, it indicates suggestibility.**

13. Glove Anaesthesia Test:

The subject is asked to imagine one of their hands becoming numb and insensitive as if wearing an anaesthetic glove. The ability to feel less sensation or none at all in that hand indicates suggestibility.

14. Breath Control Test: **The subject is asked to take deep breaths and imagine each breath making them more relaxed and calm. Observing changes in their breathing pattern and relaxation level indicates suggestibility.**

15. Imaginary Weight Test: **The subject is asked to imagine holding a heavy object in one hand and a light object in the other. Observing if one arm lowers and the other rises as imagined indicates suggestibility.**

16. Hand Lock Test: **The subject is instructed to clasp their hands together and imagine they are locked and cannot be separated. If the hands remain clasped despite efforts to separate them, it indicates suggestibility.**

17. Magnetic Fingers Test: **The subject is asked to extend their hands in front of them, palms facing each other, with fingers slightly apart. The hypnotist suggests that the fingers are magnets and will start to draw together. If the fingers move closer without conscious effort, it indicates suggestibility.** **18. Balloon Test:** **The subject is asked to imagine a balloon between the hands and now it is being inflated more and more. If the hands move accordingly, it shows suggestibility.**

19. Suggestion of Heat or Cold: **The hypnotist suggests that one part of the subject's body (e.g., a hand) is becoming warm or cold. A noticeable change in temperature perception indicates suggestibility.**

20. Taste Suggestion Test: **The subject is asked to imagine tasting a specific flavour, such as sweet, sour, or bitter. A physical reaction to the imagined taste (like salivation or a facial expression) suggests high suggestibility.**

21. Foot Stuck to the Floor Test:

The subject is asked to imagine that their feet are glued or stuck to the floor and that they cannot lift them. Difficulty in lifting the feet indicates suggestibility.

22. Automatic Writing Test: **The subject is given a pen and paper and asked to allow their hand to write automatically, without conscious control, while imagining they are writing a specific word or phrase. If the hand moves and writes as suggested, it indicates suggestibility.**

23. Hand Clasp Test: **The subject is asked to clasp their hands together and imagine that they are stuck. If they struggle to separate their hands, it indicates suggestibility.**

24. Hallucination Test: **The subject is asked to visualize a simple object, such as a red ball, and to describe it in detail. The clarity and detail of their description can indicate their level of suggestibility.**

24. Body Stiffness Test: **The subject is asked to imagine their entire body becoming stiff and rigid, like a board, and unable to bend. If they feel their body stiffen, it indicates suggestibility.**

25. Voice Changing Test: **The hypnotist suggests that the subject's voice is changing in pitch or tone. If the subject's voice changes as suggested, it indicates suggestibility.**

26. Emotional Suggestion Test:

The subject is asked to imagine a specific emotion, such as happiness or sadness, and to notice any changes in their feelings or expressions. A strong emotional response to the suggestion indicates suggestibility.

27. Positive Hallucination Test:

The subject is asked to imagine seeing or hearing something that is not actually present (e.g., an imaginary person or sound). If they act as though they perceive the suggested hallucination, it indicates suggestibility. These tests are often used during the induction phase of hypnosis. These tests provide a range of ways to assess how responsive an individual is to hypnotic suggestions. They help the hypnotist understand the subject's mental state and adjust their approach for optimal results.

Enhancing Suggestibility: **Techniques for enhancing suggestibility in therapeutic settings: Enhancing suggestibility involves techniques that optimize a person's responsiveness to therapeutic suggestions during hypnosis. These techniques leverage psychological principles to create a conducive environment for positive change.**

1. Visualization: Using guided imagery to enhance suggestibility involves vividly describing scenarios or sensations that encourage the client to imagine and experience therapeutic outcomes. For example, a therapist might guide a client through imagining themselves confidently delivering a presentation without anxiety.

2. Positive Framing: Framing suggestions positively involves phrasing statements in a way that focuses on desired outcomes. This technique helps align suggestions with the client's goals and values, fostering receptivity. For instance, suggesting "You feel calm and in control" rather than "You do not feel anxious."

3. Progressive Relaxation: By systematically relaxing the body and mind, progressive relaxation techniques reduce resistance and increase openness to therapeutic suggestions. This method is effective in helping clients achieve a state of deep relaxation conducive to positive change.

building rapport and trust with clients or subjects: Establishing rapport and trust is foundational in any therapeutic setting, including hypnosis. It creates a safe and supportive environment where clients feel comfortable exploring and accepting therapeutic suggestions. Example: Initial sessions often focus on building rapport through active listening, empathy, and demonstrating a genuine commitment to understanding the client's concerns and goals. This establishes a strong therapeutic alliance, enhancing the effectiveness of subsequent hypnosis sessions.

Challenges and Limitations: Common challenges faced in working with suggestibility: Navigating the variability in individual responses to suggestions is a common challenge in hypnosis. Factors such as personality, past experiences, and psychological traits influence how clients respond to therapeutic suggestions. Example: A client with a highly analytical mindset may require different approaches compared to someone who is more intuitive or emotionally sensitive. Understanding these variations helps tailor therapeutic strategies effectively. Ethical dilemmas and precautions when using suggestibility in practice: Ethical considerations are paramount when using suggestibility in therapeutic practice. Respecting client autonomy, ensuring informed consent, and maintaining ethical boundaries are critical to ethical practice. Example: It's essential to clarify therapeutic goals, obtain informed consent, and avoid suggestions that could compromise a client's values or beliefs. This ensures that hypnosis is used responsibly and ethically to promote positive outcomes without infringing on personal autonomy. By employing effective techniques to enhance suggestibility and addressing potential challenges and ethical considerations, practitioners can use hypnosis responsibly and effectively in therapeutic settings to promote positive change and well-being.

Formulating Suggestions
Saying "yes" while shaking one's head "no" is incongruent.

1. Use Positive Statements:

o Focus on what you want, not what you don't want. Instead of thinking about the problem, imagine the solution and the desired outcome.
o Example:
▪ Incorrect: "I am not stressed."
▪ Correct: "I am calm and at peace."

2. Awareness is Key:

o What you focus on expands. When you give mental energy to something, you attract more of it into your life. Direct your affirmations toward the result you want, rather than the problem.
o Example:
▪ Incorrect: "I am in control of my appetite." (It still focuses on the idea of controlling something.)
▪ Correct: "I eat only as much as I need to nourish my body perfectly."

3. Use the Present Tense.

I will diet until I lose _____ lbs. (incorrect - this gives you the opportunity to do it later and it implies that you are losing something. You may trick yourself into letting yourself lapse today by this wording.) + I am more and more slender each and every day. (correct. The conscious mind knows that this suggestion is future based, but present improved. The subconscious can make oneself comfortable using of open ended life affirming ideas.)

4. Be Specific.

Carefully state exactly what you desire, avoiding slang or wording with multiple meanings. - I am losing 20 lbs. (incorrect - my mind goes nuts when I lose things. I do not want to lose weight and find it, again. I must shed, reduce, discard, take off, eliminate, get rid of, throw away.) + Each and every day, I am closer and closer to my goal of _____ lbs. (or size_____). (correct)

5. Use "I Am"

Each and very day, more and more relaxed. (incorrect - who is doing it? There is power in the words, "I am." They are the same words used by the voice from the

burning bush, with Moses. Write your affirmations in the first person, in the present tense.)

How to Edit Affirmations

1. Be Specific and Use Present Tense:
Ensure your affirmations are clear and written in the present tense. This helps your mind
accept the change as happening right now.

2. Review and Relax:
After writing your affirmations, take a few minutes to relax and enter a light self-hypnosis
state. This helps you focus and deeply connect with your affirmations.

3. Discard Uncomfortable Affirmations:
As you review your affirmations, discard any that make you feel uneasy or uncomfortable.
Affirmations should feel empowering, not forced.

4. Affirm the Method and Result:
Be sure to include both the process and the outcome in your affirmations. This allows you
to affirm the approach as well as the end result, creating a sense of confidence in both.

5. Bypass Doubts:
To bypass any logical objections, you can use techniques like ideomotor finger response (a
technique where your fingers subtly move in response to your subconscious) to check if the
affirmation resonates with you.

One Word Key / Hypnotic Triggers:

Select the word or short phrase which symbolizes the entire goal toward which you are striving. Regarding a
weight issue, one might key in with: slender, sexy, shapely, attractive, trim, slim, fit, limber, etc . . .
“Once you have selected your trigger word, close your eyes and say the word. Does it feel right?”
“Once you are satisfied with the way you feel about your keyword, write it down.”

Using the One Word Key / Hypnotic Triggers:

“Whenever I say, hear, see, think the word or phrase _____, it automatically reinforces all of these affirmations.”

Post Hypnotic Suggestions:

Two types of post hypnotic suggestions:

1 - Response projected or continued into the waking state.
2 - Response elicited from sudden signal or subconscious message or stimulus.

(An example of a projected post hypnotic suggestion:)

“That’s fine. When you emerge from trance, and return to full waking state, you will remember to forget all about _____.”

Another projected example:

“That’s fine, as I count from five to one, you will return to full waking state feeling better than you felt before, better than you have felt in a long time,

An elicitation example:

“That's fine, close your eyes. When I have you open your eyes, any time you see me _____ /hypnotic trigger/ you will instantly _____ /post hypnotic suggestion/. You won't remember that I gave you this suggestion but you will react to it. You can forget consciously this whole conversation, but any time I ___ /hypnotic trigger/, you are going to ____/post hypnotic suggestion/. It will happen instantaneously. You won't remember that I gave this suggestion. Forget the whole conversation, but be guided by it. All right, now open your eyes, please. How do you feel?

Sample Affirmations for Weight Reduction:

• "I am more relaxed with myself. I am becoming more aware of my feelings and express
myself appropriately. I desire to attain and maintain the healthiest weight for my body."

• "Every day, I am growing more and more comfortable with myself and embracing my
worth. I am increasingly aware of my own beauty."

• "Every day, in every way, I am thinking, acting, and moving toward my ideal weight,
growing more confident with each passing day."

• "I eat just enough to nourish my body perfectly. I listen to my body and provide it with the
mental, physical, emotional, and spiritual nourishment it needs."

• "I trust myself more every day. I enjoy the way my body feels when I exercise—whether
walking, swimming, biking, dancing, going to the gym, or moving in ways that support my
well-being."

• "As I discover a sustainable, enjoyable routine for diet and exercise, it becomes easier each
day to reach and maintain my optimal weight."

• "I now enjoy foods that nourish my body and make me feel good. I am increasingly satisfied
with myself."

• "I eat only what my body needs to sustain its perfect health because I am worth it."

• "I take responsibility for my thoughts, feelings, words, and actions. As I imagine myself
slender, that image becomes more real in my mind and body."

• "I enjoy moments of exercise throughout the day as I incorporate healthy movement into
my daily activities, helping me feel more limber and relaxed."

• "Today, I choose to embrace who I am, feeling more relaxed and at ease with myself each
and every day."